FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The BJP versus the Congress. Head to head. In almost all 520 constituencies across three states. For all the buzzing confusion that has crept into our polity in recent decades, there's such an alluring simplicity to that basic two-party formula that it has endured. It carries the charm of a medieval duel, or a famous tennis rivalry. But within the grid of that bipolar fight, there resides another interesting bipolarity. Ever since Prime Minister Narendra Modi strode on to the national stage like a colossus, the BJP has had an unparalleled dominance at the macro level. But whenever the contest shifts to arenas at the local level, it finds its stature as unquestioned supremo slipping away. Almost like a Wimbledon champion playing on the clay court at Roland Garros: the pace of the game is different, the ball comes on differently, the slowness is exacting and exposes weaknesses that otherwise do not show. Consider the assembly contests coming up in three Hindi heartland states: Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. Even though the BJP is an established player with deep roots in all three, the saffron party is forced to play the game as an equal rather than as an invincible. The odds of victory and defeat level out.



October 23, 2023

This pattern is especially salient whenever the BJP comes up against a singularly strong entity comfortable on the local turf. Mostly that role has been played by regional leaders who are popular in their own backyards. Say, a Nitish Kumar in Bihar, a Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, or Naveen Patnaik in Odisha. That's why there is a two-sidedness to India's democracy: the BJP has a brute 303-seat majority in the Lok Sabha, but rules only six out of the 22 mainland states directly, including tiny Goa. One of the big ones in that six was secured by defections: Madhya Pradesh. As was the seventh that it rules in alliance: Maharashtra. It has none in the South unless Puducherry is counted, where it's a junior partner. It's only when you include its clean sweep of the Northeast, where Assam is the only major state among the four it rules with a majority, that the BJP's score looks better.

The Congress comes into this equation from a different direction. Battered and bruised nationally for a decade, it has often appeared either complacent or defeatist in elections. This time, by contrast, it shows a new buoyancy. The reasons have been trotted out fairly often: Rahul Gandhi turning a corner with the Bharat Jodo Yatra, and the electoral wins in Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka. The past record also presents some interesting pointers for the battles ahead. Not only had the Congress won the three big northern trophies presently at stake back in 2018, it had made the BJP sweat all the way to the finishing line even in its strongest fortress, Gujarat, in 2017. This capacity is reflected in the state-level political map. The Congress rules four out of 22 mainland states with a majority. As a junior UPA alliance partner, it can count three more. Suddenly the equation seems more even: UPA seven, NDA eight.

It's this arena that buzzes with the air of anticipation typical before a big fight. Our cover story this week analyses the strategies of the two big players in these state elections and the reality on the ground. Executive Editor Kaushik Deka and Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan in New Delhi, with ground inputs from Deputy Editor Rohit Parihar in Jaipur and Senior Associate Editor Rahul Noronha in Bhopal/ Raipur, give the top-down view of the trends as well as the myriad of grassroots nuances whose aggregate makes up the big picture. Of course, even if state results are specific to that level and in no way guarantee a spillover nationally, they are bound to generate momentum for either the BJP or the Congress. Beyond that, these states will be the laboratory where the new Mandal turn to Indian politics will be tested. Going against the traditional stand of his party and family—both Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi opposed reservations—Rahul has steered the Congress towards an overtly pro-backwards stance. The party has promised to conduct a caste survey in the states it wins, and has taken to enthusiastically backing the demand nationally. This strategic positioning, it believes, is the silver bullet with which to slay Hindutva. The BJP plans to blunt this edge by marrying saffron politics with a kaleidoscope of caste colours at the micro level, without necessarily giving in to the demand.

But the politics of representation is just one element. While it decries '*revdi*' culture as fiscal profligacy, the BJP is also building up an emerging constituency of '*labharthis*'. Just in case beneficiaries of welfare schemes don't add up, it has also lobbed in a good number of goodies onto its gift hamper—take cash doleouts to women, or the timely benevolence of LPG cylinder price cuts. The Congress, with its own Santa Claus sack spilling over with promised gifts, is hardly willing to be left behind in competitive populism. Farm loan waivers, higher MSPs, the Old Pension Scheme, cash handouts to women and unemployed youth, there's something for everyone in its department store shelves. The Grand Old Party's forthcoming 'Padho Padhao Yojana' in Madhya Pradesh promises free education for students between classes 1 and 12 and a monthly scholarship ranging from Rs 500 to Rs 1,500. Freebie or welfare? Well, it depends on the eyes of the giver. There's enough here for a good lawyer to argue on both sides.

The compelling element about this contest for the hearts and minds—and stomachs—of voters is that every election actually presents a novel situation. The past does throw up patterns, but there's no law which dictates that history will be repeated. The BJP's oxygen is the Hindi heartland and losses here could seriously damage its prospects for the general election next year. Especially since it is not projecting any local leader as a potential chief minister and the elections are being fought in the name of Prime Minister Modi. For the Congress, it is a fight to establish a pre-eminence in the INDIA bloc for the general election and to reclaim its mojo as the only other national party. The stakes are palpably high for both sides and the battle promises to be fierce.

(Aroon Purie)